



FLAGSHIP PM PROGRAM · CAPSTONE ASSIGNMENT

Validate the opportunity.

Manager briefing → interviews → design methods → synthesis. One feature, end to end.



Name	Cohort	Submitted
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What you'll do.

You've learned the first half of feature opportunity validation: the manager briefing, and how to refine user value through interviews and design methods. This assignment puts it all together on one feature. You'll take a feature brief handed to you, the way a real leader would hand it over, build the manager briefing, plan how you'd validate the user value through both an interview and a design method, and set up the synthesis sheet that turns findings into a decision.

You are not running the research here. You are producing the plan a teammate could pick up and run.

PART A

Manager briefing

Turn the feature brief into three hypotheses: strategic fit, user value, business value.

Outcome: a briefing document ready to align with a manager.

PART B

Interview plan

Define 6 users, work out the recruitment funnel, and write a staged interview guide.

Outcome: an interview you could run tomorrow.

PART C

Design method plan

Decide interview versus design method, set the three knobs, and spec the stimulus.

Outcome: a design-method session, fully specced.

PART D

Synthesis setup

Set up the refine-user-value sheet that captures findings and drives the go/no-go.

Outcome: an empty synthesis template, ready to fill.

How you'll be graded

Each part carries a weight. The full rubric sits on the last page. Read it before you start, not after you finish.

Do Part A on your own thinking first. Resist reaching for AI until you know what good looks like. Use the Ayuda artifacts where the assignment tells you to.

Ayuda Question Rewriter · grades and rewrites your interview questions

Ayuda Interview Studio · the interview **playbook** and **rewriter** in one place

The brief you've been handed.

A leader has handed you the following feature idea, a couple of paragraphs straight from the tip of the iceberg. Everything you build in this assignment starts here.

FEATURE BRIEF 01

Product. A consumer wealth-and-payments app (UPI plus investing), India, roughly 8M monthly active users, mostly ages 22 to 35.

Feature idea, "Round-Up Investing".

"Every time a user makes a UPI payment, we round the amount up to the next ₹10 and quietly invest the spare change into a low-risk fund. Pay ₹47 for a coffee, ₹3 goes into investing. The pitch is that people who never start investing because it feels intimidating, or because they 'never have money left over', will start building a corpus without noticing. I keep seeing young users who use us daily for payments but have never opened an investment. I think this is our bridge. Can you look into whether this is worth building, whether users actually want it, and whether it moves our numbers?"

What the leader did not specify. Who exactly this is for, how big the problem really is, what people do today instead, or what "moves our numbers" means. That's your job.

This is the brief for everyone. Work on it in your own time and submit the completed document.

01

Manager briefing

Turn the idea into three hypotheses, before you talk to a single user.



WHAT YOU'RE DOING

You're not going to your users yet. First you write down your own best-guess hypotheses about why this feature will work, across three angles, and prepare to pressure-test them with your manager. A hypothesis is a falsifiable guess. It must be provable wrong.

WHY IT MATTERS

The biggest risk in product is trusting an idea nobody validated. The briefing forces the idea out of the tip-of-the-iceberg stage and into something testable.

A1 · Strategic fit Outcome: a yes or no from your manager

Strategic fit is alignment on fundamentals. Fill all five. For mission and vision, do not copy-paste the company's. Take the real mission and vision and tweak them to fit this feature. For company strategy, product strategy and team goals, write your best understanding. These usually come top-down from your manager, so leave room for their input.

Element	Your entry
Mission, tweaked to this feature	
Vision, tweaked to this feature	
Company strategy <i>Current priorities this feature must sit inside</i>	
Product strategy <i>What the product is optimizing for now</i>	
Team goals <i>The specific metrics your team owns</i>	
Manager's yes/no and notes <i>Filled after the briefing conversation</i>	

COMMON MISTAKE

If you genuinely cannot tweak the mission or vision to fit, even via a cost or scale angle, this may not be a strategic fit at all. Flag it, don't force it.

A2 · User value hypothesis Outcome: a go-ahead to run user research

This is the heart of the briefing and the bulk of your work. It has three blocks: profile, problem, goals. No numbers are required to be accurate here. These are hypotheses from your immersion. But be specific.

BLOCK 1 · USER PROFILE HYPOTHESIS

Demographic (B2C) or firmographic (B2B) <i>Age, location, income, occupation, or company type and size</i>	
Product behaviour and usage pattern <i>How they use the product today, and what is unique about their usage</i>	

BLOCK 2 · USER PROBLEM HYPOTHESIS

Problem area <i>Which part of their experience hurts</i>	
Signals of the problem <i>Complaints, social chatter, behaviour you have seen</i>	
Severity <i>Quality issue, or a trust and values issue?</i>	
Estimated number of users impacted <i>A range is fine, from immersion, not precise data</i>	
Alternatives used today <i>What they do instead, without you. Note your proposed feature as your chosen approach</i>	

BLOCK 3 · USER GOALS HYPOTHESIS

Qualitative goals <i>What a good outcome feels like for the user</i>	
Quantitative goals <i>What would drop or rise for them</i>	
Non-goals <i>What you are explicitly not solving</i>	

The goal of A2 is to surface the nuances of user value with your manager and earn a yes to go research it. The manager cannot validate user value. They can only give you the green light to test it. That test is Parts B, C and D.

A3 · Business value hypothesis Outcome: your manager flags any missed costs

Business value is easy to hypothesize and hard to prove. Proof comes later. Here you just need a realistic, assumed picture. Two blocks, stakeholders and goals, and every business goal should map to one of the five money levers.

THE FIVE MONEY LEVERS

More users pay

Users pay more

Users renew and retain more

Users engage more

Company saves cost or time

BLOCK 1 · KEY STAKEHOLDERS

Decision makers

Who must sign off

Informed circle

*Who needs to be told or trained
but does not approve*

BLOCK 2 · BUSINESS GOALS

Goal type	Your entry	Lever it maps to
Qualitative goals		
Quantitative goals <i>Estimated ranges, from immersion</i>		
Non-goals <i>Business outcomes you are explicitly not chasing</i>		

The goal of A3 is not a yes or no. It is for your manager to flag obvious costs or issues you missed, such as training load or support burden. End of Part A: you have a briefing ready to align on, and a go-ahead to refine user value.

02

Interview plan

Validate the user value hypothesis. Talk to the right 6 users, the right way.



WHAT YOU'RE DOING

You have the go-ahead to research. Interviews are the primary tool for refining user value at this stage. You'll plan four things: the hypothesis to test from Part A, the 6 users, the questions, and how you'll capture insights.

B1 • The hypothesis to interview on

Pull the three hypotheses from your Part A user value block: profile, problem, goals. Restate them here in one place. This is what every interview is trying to validate.

Profile hypothesis	
Problem hypothesis	
Goals hypothesis	

B2 • Define your 6 users

You interview 6 users, a research-validated number where insights start repeating. All six share the common attributes from your profile hypothesis. Each one adds one unique trait so you get varied perspectives. Build brick by brick: start with demography (age bands, then gender split, then location, then income and family size), then layer peculiar habits related to the feature. Don't just bump the age up six times. Mix and match, and add habits so the personas aren't a bland progression of the same person.

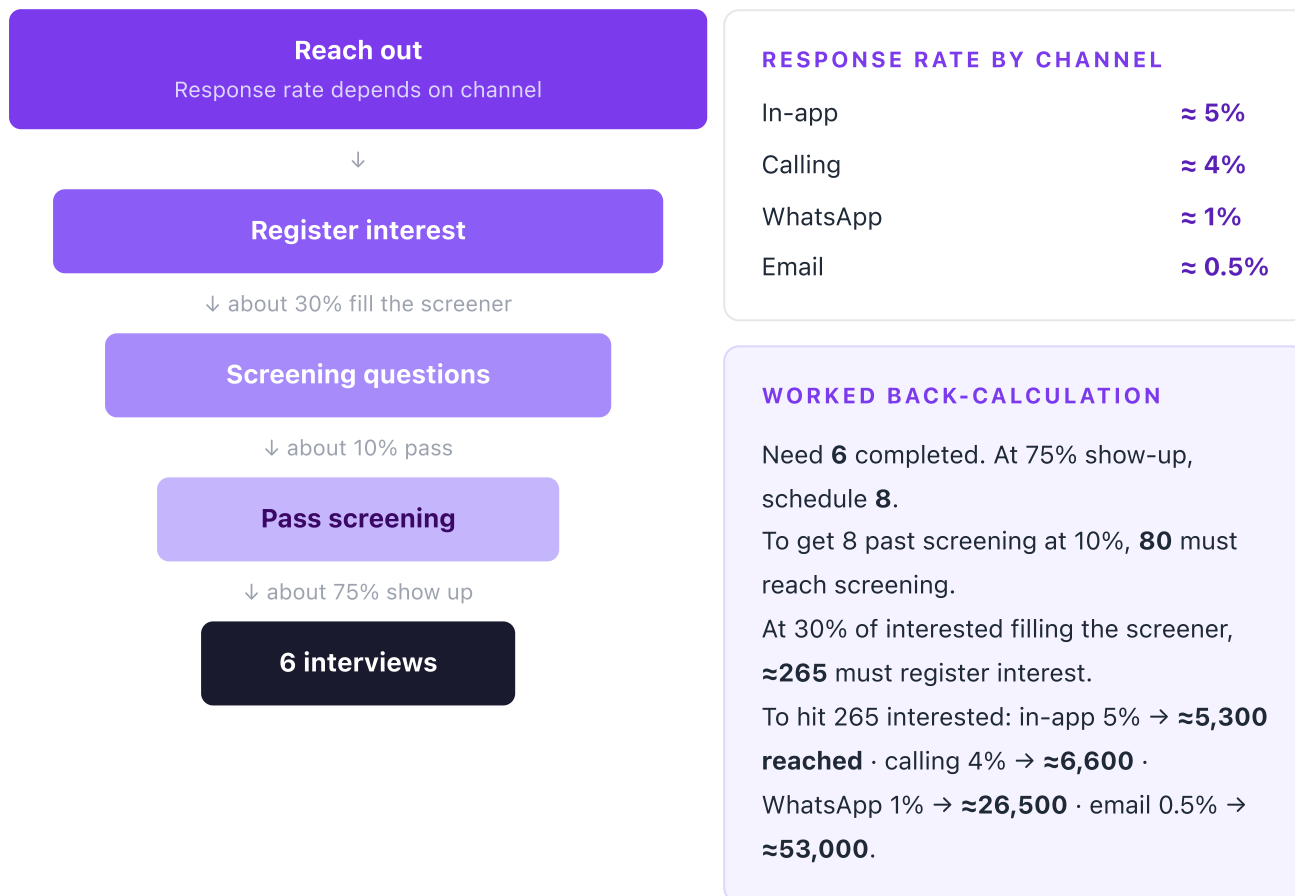
Common attributes <i>Shared by all six, from your profile hypothesis</i>	
--	--

#	Age band	Gender	Location	Income / family	Peculiar habit	Persona in one line
1						
2						
3						
4						
5						
6						

The peculiar-habit column is where depth comes from. Pick a habit that reveals how they relate to the problem, for example someone who moves money to a separate account the day salary lands.

B3 · The recruitment funnel

Getting 6 people on a call is a funnel with drop-off at every step. You'll back-calculate from 6, then choose your outreach channel. Demographics are handled in your master data. Peculiar habits are handled by screening questions.



Incentives, for example a ₹500 voucher, can lift response rates several-fold and shrink the top of the funnel. Calling gives the best quality in the Indian ecosystem. In-app users are the most motivated.

YOUR RECRUITMENT PLAN

Channel	Response rate assumed	People to reach	Interested needed	Screened needed	Scheduled needed	Incentive

Screening questions

*Two or three that check
your peculiar habits, not
demographics*

B4 · The staged interview guide

An interview is a hike. You walk them up, you never parachute to the peak. Three stages.

STAGE 1 Build psychological safety

about 5 min

Introduce yourself, explain the research without revealing the specific hypothesis, ask permission to record for internal use, then have genuine human small talk.

People's first instinct is to say what they think you want to hear, and they don't know what's technically possible. Lower the guard first. Line to use: "You can't hurt my feelings, it's not my project, I'm here to learn."

Your two or three warm-up prompts

STAGE 2 Immerse in context

about 10 min

Get them to recall about five real past events around the topic, so they answer from memory rather than a half-baked guess.

An out-of-context question gets a half-baked answer based on their most recent memory. Make them think about several real events first.

The five real events or immersion prompts you'll use

STAGE 3 Real validation questions

30 to 45 min

Seven to ten questions that test your hypotheses. Number them.

THE FIVE TESTS EVERY STAGE-3 QUESTION MUST PASS

- | | |
|--|--|
| 1 Open-ended
Invites a story, not a yes or no. | 2 Non-leading
Doesn't embed the answer you want. |
| 3 Behaviour, not opinion
What they did, not what they think or would do. | 4 One core idea
Not double-barrelled. |
| 5 Never asked directly
Time-anchored: "walk me through the last time..." | |

The most versatile phrase in research: **"Walk me through the last time you..."**

Required tool step[Ayuda Question Rewriter](#)

Take at least three of your Stage-3 questions and run them through the Question Rewriter. Paste the before and after for each, and note which of the five tests the original failed.

Original question	Tests it failed	Rewritten question

03

Design method plan

Don't just ask. Show them something and watch them react.



WHAT YOU'RE DOING

Design methods are the second way to refine user value. Instead of asking users to imagine, you give them a stimulus and watch them react. The first two steps, hypothesis and users, are identical to the interview. What changes is that you plan a design method instead of questions.

C1 • Interview or design method

First decide whether this feature is better validated by an interview, a design method, or both. Use the decision criteria.

Use interviews when...	Use design methods when...
The product or feature is simple and daily-use	The product or feature is complex and not daily-use
The user is deeply immersed, often B2B	The user is not heavily immersed
You have little time and are optimizing for speed	You have time to invest
You're already confident in the hypothesis	You're unsure and want more validation

Your choice and why

Which method or methods, reasoned against the criteria above

C2 • Set the three knobs

Every design method is three knobs: activity, stimulus, role. They move together, and incoherent settings produce garbage. Set all three.

KNOB 1**Activity**

What the user does

Give reactions to the stimulus

Give reasons for their actions

Explain the utility or missing pieces

Just use the stimulus

KNOB 2**Stimulus**

What they see

Sketch

Wireframe

Vibe-prototype design

Vibe-coded product, front-end only or front and back-end

KNOB 3**Role**

How you behave

Observer, tracked via Microsoft Clarity or Mixpanel

Guide, speak only when they're stuck

Active probe, back-and-forth on everything

Activity	Valid role or roles
Give reactions	Observer or guide
Give reasons for actions	Active probe
Explain utility or missing pieces	Guide or active probe
Use the stimulus	Observer only

Activity	Stimulus and fidelity	Role	Pairing valid?

COMMON MISTAKE

If you pick "use the stimulus", you must be an observer, so set up Clarity to record. If you pick active probe, know that your back-and-forth will muddy the session recording. Lean on the conversation for insight, not the heatmap.

C3 · Spec the stimulus

Decide exactly what's in your stimulus, what's out, and its fidelity. In the post-LLM world the expectation is a vibe-prototyped design, or a vibe-coded product if you need a real back-end, not a hand-drawn wireframe.

What's in the stimulus	
What's out, deliberately excluded	
Fidelity level chosen	
Why this fidelity <i>Matched to how strong your hypothesis is</i>	

C4 · The design-method process document

Write the short run-sheet you'd follow live. The first two stages, psychological safety and immersion, are the same as the interview. Then you give the design-method exercise instead of questions, then you summarize.

How will you share the stimulus? <i>Link, tracked via Clarity, shared in advance or on the call</i>	
What exactly will you say to set up the activity?	
How will you hold your chosen role consistently?	

04

Synthesis setup

Build the sheet that turns raw findings into a go or no-go.



WHAT YOU'RE DOING

You won't have real findings yet. You're setting up the refine-user-value template so that when the interviews and design sessions happen, the findings flow straight into a decision. Pre-fill what you already know, the hypotheses and personas, and leave the findings columns empty.

D1 • Background, hypothesis details

List every user-value hypothesis you're testing, coded. These come straight from your Part A user value block.

Hypothesis ID	Validation method	Hypothesis description
<i>HYP01</i>		
<i>HYP02</i>		
<i>HYP03</i>		
<i>HYP04</i>		

D2 • Background, target audience

Bring your 6 personas from Part B.

Persona ID	Common attributes	Unique traits	Demographic traits
P1			
P2			
P3			
P4			
P5			
P6			

D3 · Validation, per hypothesis

For each hypothesis, and for each method used, you'll capture findings in this structure. Set up one empty block per hypothesis.

VALIDATION BLOCK HYP01					Method: interview / design method
Persona ID	Specific user details	Notes from session	Observations	Validation outcome	Validation notes

Validation outcome is one of: supports, contradicts, new finding. Duplicate this block for each hypothesis, and add a separate sub-table if a hypothesis used both interviews and a design method.

D4 · Final decision

Hypothesis ID	Next step	Next-step explanation

Proceed to refine business value

More user validation needed

Invalidate, go back to your manager

D5 · Connect it to Claude

[Google Drive connector](#)

Once your sheet is set up, connect it to Claude via a Google Drive connector so you can ask questions across all your findings and discuss with your manager without scrolling 400 rows. Note which connector you'll use and where the sheet lives.

Connector and sheet location	

How you'll be graded.

Part	What we're looking for	Weight
Part A Manager briefing	All three hypotheses complete. Mission and vision genuinely tweaked to the feature, not copy-pasted. Problem hypothesis has all five parts with real signals. Business goals mapped to the five levers. Non-goals used well.	25%
Part B Interview plan	Six personas share common attributes with distinct, non-bland unique traits across demography and peculiar habits. Recruitment funnel correctly back-calculated for the chosen channel. Three-stage guide with a safe warm-up and real-event immersion. Stage-3 questions pass the five tests. Three or more questions shown before and after the Question Rewriter with the failed tests named.	30%
Part C Design method plan	Interview versus design-method choice justified against the criteria. Three knobs set as a valid, coherent pairing. Stimulus specced with in, out, fidelity and reasoning. Process document holds the role consistently.	25%
Part D Synthesis setup	Template correctly structured. Hypotheses coded and carried through. Personas carried through. Validation and decision tables set up with the right columns and options. Claude connection noted.	20%

SUBMISSION

Export this filled document as a PDF and upload it. Do Part A on your own thinking before using AI. Use the Question Rewriter and Interview Studio where the assignment directs you.

Bring your synthesis sheet to the next session. We'll pressure-test business value from there.